

Allow and prohibit

Teaching guide

Explain permission and restrictions clearly.

Understand the distinction

Allow commonly takes a person plus to + verb: They allow visitors to take photos. Without a named person, use an -ing form: They allow photography / taking photos. The passive is be allowed to.

Prohibit commonly takes an activity or person + from + -ing: The rules prohibit parking here; they prohibit visitors from entering. Must not expresses a prohibition. Do not have to expresses lack of obligation, which is different.

Compare the patterns

PERMISSION

Visitors are allowed to take photos.

Taking photos is permitted.

PROHIBITION

Parking here is prohibited.

Parking here is not permitted.

NO OBLIGATION

You do not have to print the ticket.

Printing is optional, not forbidden.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete: They allow us ___ leave early.

A. from

B. for

C. to

2. Complete: The rule prohibits staff from ___ here. (smoke)

A. to smoke

B. smoke

C. smoking

3. Does You do not have to wait mean waiting is forbidden?

A. No. It means you are required to wait.

B. No. Waiting is not required.

C. Yes. It means you must not wait.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. The kitchen is available, but leaving the door unlocked is forbidden. Which notice gives both rules?

A. You may use the kitchen. You do not have to leave the door unlocked.

B. You may use the kitchen. You must not leave the door unlocked.

C. You must not use the kitchen. You may leave the door unlocked.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. to

Use allow someone to do something.

A: From would require a different pattern, such as prevent someone from doing something.

B: Allow someone to do something is the pattern here.

2. C. smoking

Use from + -ing.

A: Use from smoking, not from to smoke.

B: From is followed by the -ing form in this pattern.

3. B. No. Waiting is not required.

Use must not wait if it is prohibited.

A: The negative do not have to means waiting is optional.

C: Do not have to removes necessity; must not expresses prohibition.

4. B. You may use the kitchen. You must not leave the door unlocked.

May gives permission; must not gives the restriction.

A: Do not have to means not required; it does not forbid leaving the door unlocked.

C: This reverses both rules.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-13.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

The kitchen is available, but leaving the door unlocked is forbidden. Which notice gives both rules?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.